



Harper Vale

FOOD CRITIC

“Has never met a dish that couldn’t be improved by a sharper adjective.”



✦ FOR YOUR EYES ONLY ✦

OPTIONAL · JOINS AT 5+

WHAT TO WEAR

A velvet jacket, a bold bow tie or brooch, and a little notebook and pencil for taking notes on every course.

At the table you are: theatrical, witty and impossible to impress.

How this booklet works



Before the party: read page 2 alone. It holds your story and your secret.



Starter served: open Round 1 on page 3 when the host calls it.



Main course served: unfold page 3 and open Round 2.



Dessert served: open Round 3 on page 4, then vote.

Printed single-sided, so later rounds can’t show through.



THE EVENING

Autumn, the 1930s. Bartholomew “Barty” Thistle, retired jam magnate, has invited a few old friends to the Harvest Supper at Thistledown House. Before the soup was served, Barty took a glass of elderflower cordial in the study, sat down for a rest, and never woke up. Someone at this table knows why.

Never show this booklet to anyone. You may bend the truth about your secret, but never about the evidence.



You are innocent.

You did not harm Barty, and you want the truth to come out.

You are an optional character. If you are not in the game, nothing breaks.

Your story

You write the “Table Talk” column for the London Evening Courier. Last spring you wrote that Thistle’s Harvest Jam “tastes of regret and boiled string.” Tonight’s invitation was either a peace offering or a trap.

YOUR SECRET

Last week a solicitor’s letter on Barty’s behalf demanded £300 and a printed apology for your review. You have no intention of paying. You also wandered down the study corridor at about 5:40, looking for the telephone.

Where you were

5:30	Arrived by motor car.
about 5:40	Down the study corridor looking for the telephone.
5:45–6:10	In the dining room, admiring the table.
6:10–6:25	On the hall telephone to the Courier. The operator rang back at 6:25 with the charges.
6:30	Sherry in the drawing room.

Your goal tonight

Get a scoop for your column and find the truth. Keep the lawsuit quiet until Round 2.

If someone asks you...

“Did you hate Barty?” “I hated the jam. Barty I rather liked.”

“Why were you in the hall?” “Telephoning my editor. The operator will confirm the time.”

“Did you see anything?” “From the telephone I can see the main stairs, and not much else.”

YOUR NOTES BEFORE THE PARTY

Harper Vale • Rounds 1 & 2

ONE ROUND AT A TIME



Round 1 • Starter

OPEN ONLY WHEN THE HOST CALLS IT

Read only when the Starter is served.

SHARE THIS • I came to write a column about the Harvest Supper. I did not come to like Barty's jam.

- From about ten past six until twenty-five past I was on the hall telephone to my editor. The operator rang back with the charges at 6:25.

ASK

- **Morgan:** “What did Barty plan for tonight’s menu?”
- **Rowan:** “Did Barty ever forgive anybody for anything?”

YOUR TASK Taste the starter with great ceremony and give it a short spoken review.



FOLD OR CUT HERE · KEEP ROUND 2 HIDDEN UNTIL THE MAIN COURSE IS SERVED



Round 2 · Main Course

OPEN ONLY WHEN THE HOST CALLS IT

Read only when the Main Course is served.

SHARE THIS • A solicitor's letter on Barty's behalf demanded £300 and an apology for my review. The solicitor who signed it is sitting at this table.

- As I hung up at 6:25, I saw Sage coming down the main stairs. Not out of the library, mind. Down the stairs.

ASK

- **Sage:** “Do you always write such fierce letters for your clients?”
- **Ellis:** “Is it true that Barty’s heart was strong?”

YOUR TASK Write a one-line “review” of another suspect’s alibi in your notes and read it out.

NOTES • ROUNDS 1 AND 2

“MUST SHARE” lines are true and important. Say them during the round, in your own words.

Harper Vale • Round 3

THEN VOTE

Round 3 · Dessert

OPEN ONLY WHEN THE HOST CALLS IT

Read only when the Dessert is served.

SHARE THIS

- I admit I wandered down the study corridor at about 5:40, looking for the telephone. The door was shut and I heard Barty and Rowan talking about money.
- Word in London is that a country solicitor has been “living rather above their means.”

ASK

- **Sage:** “How does a country solicitor afford a new motor car?”
- **Rowan:** “What did you and Barty argue about at twenty to six?”

YOUR TASK Award the evening's best course a star rating out of five, aloud.

NOTES

SUSPECTS AT A GLANCE (PUBLIC INFORMATION)

#	NAME	ROLE	#	NAME	ROLE
10	Rowan Thistle	Heir to Thistledown House	14	Harper Vale	Food Critic
11	Ellis Fairweather	Family Doctor	15	Quinn Ashby	Head Gardener
12	Morgan Pike	Steward of Thistledown House	16	Avery Lark	Newspaper Reporter
13	Sage Whitlock	Family Solicitor	17	Jules Marchetti	Visiting Chef